

MASS TROUBLE
Rebel priests protest at the Syro-Malabar Church HQ in Kochi

controversy—over shady land deals—had rocked the church. But now the church is silent on his future.

Talking to the media on July 31, major archbishop cardinal George Alencherry, head of the Syro-Malabar Church, welcomed the Vatican's decision. "The new appointment will resolve the row amicably soon. The archbishop's responsibility is to execute the church's decisions...the synod and the Vatican are confident about archbishop Thazhathu's abilities," says Alencherry. Incidentally, he was the man in the centre of the storm in the 2018 land deals scandal where some 60 cents of prime church land in Kochi was allegedly sold for a song.

Kerala's Syro-Malabar Church, which traces its origins back to St Thomas the Apostle, is the second largest among the 23 eastern churches in the Catholic fold. It has 35 dioceses with over 4.56 million members in 2,944 parishes. The battle over the Holy Mass started in 1999 when the church decided to change a half century-old tradition with priests facing the congregation like in Latin churches. In August 2021, a synod was convened which decided to enact a uniform liturgical code. But the five dioceses—Ernakulam, Angamaly, Irinjalakuda, Thrissur, Palakkad and Thamarassery—raised the banner of revolt, saying they were against the "celebrant facing the altar [instead of the faithful] for most part of the Mass". Jaffy M. Varghese, a devout Christian who is part of the Angamaly diocese, says, "The new code has no merit... Cardinal Alencherry is using the controversy to divide the church and silence the clergy and laity who were protesting his part in the shady land deals. This is when the income-tax department has fined him Rs 3 crore and the Enforcement Directorate is investigating the matter."

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The move to depose Fr Kariyil hasn't gone down well with the community either. Theologian and media critic Fr Paul Thelakkat says this is another attempt to cover up the follies of the church. "In 1999, a synod had tried to impose the uniform code but had dropped the idea after protests in the dioceses. Cardinal Alencherry has dug out the same order and, with a letter from the Pope, has imposed it with no discussions in the synod or outside," he told INDIA TODAY. He says the text of the Holy Mass is in the form of a dialogue and asks: how can you have a dialogue with the faithful with your back turned towards them?

The church has been dilly-dallying on the uniform liturgical issue for long, with the dispute even leading to street fights among the two sides. More than 300 priests from the dioceses have opposed the move. The issue has so riven the faithful that some are even contemplating extreme steps. "Our only option now is to leave the church and attend the Latin Church mass. Let them offer the Holy Mass facing east or west," says Clara Thomas, a housewife and former catechism teacher. ■